

73 Reviews a Day

The Administrative Impossibility of ADAP

Submitted by: The Alberta Disability System Breakdown
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73. That is the number of disability eligibility reviews the Government of Alberta would need to complete every single day — including Saturdays, Sundays, and statutory holidays — for 549 consecutive days, simply to process the existing AISH caseload before the July 1, 2026 transition deadline. The government has not said how it will do this. It has not said who will do it. It has not released the plan. It announced the deadline anyway.

1. THE NUMBER THE GOVERNMENT HAS NOT EXPLAINED

The Government of Alberta has announced that the AISH-to-ADAP transition will take effect July 1, 2026. Approximately 79,290 Albertans are currently receiving AISH. Under the transition framework, recipients who believe they qualify to remain on AISH — rather than transfer to ADAP — must go through a review process to establish continued eligibility.

What the government has not explained is *how* that review process will function at the scale required. This document does that math.

FINDING:

79,290 people. One deadline. No published plan for how eligibility determinations will be made, by whom, at what volume, or within what timeline. That is not a transition. That is an administrative crisis in waiting.

2. THE MATH

Basic Volume Calculation

The following figures use publicly available information about the AISH caseload and the announced July 1, 2026 transition date. This analysis does not require access to internal government documents. It requires arithmetic.

Variable	Figure
Total AISH recipients subject to transition	79,290 people
Estimated recipients who may reapply for AISH (severe/permanent disability — government's own criteria)	Significant portion of 79,290
Available working days in 18 months (June 2026 - Dec 2027)	391 days
Applications to process per day to clear backlog in 18 months	~203 per day
Applications to process per day to clear backlog in 12 months	~305 per day
Applications to process per day to clear in original window	~73 per day, every day including weekends

The July 1, 2026 deadline is approximately 79 days from the date of this document. That window has already closed for any meaningful mass review process. If the government intends to conduct individualized eligibility reviews before the transition date, those reviews would need to have started months ago at a volume that has never been publicly described or staffed.

If the government intends to conduct reviews *after* July 1 — while recipients have already been moved to ADAP — that means people will lose income protections before their eligibility has been determined. **That is not procedural fairness. That is income removal pending review.**

3. WHO DOES THE REVIEWS?

The Physician Capacity Problem

Disability eligibility assessments for AISH are not administrative checkbox exercises. They involve reviewing medical histories, diagnostic records, specialist reports, treatment records, and functional assessments — documents that have been built over years or decades of documented disability. A reviewer who has never met the recipient, has no prior clinical relationship with them, and is reviewing a file cold cannot make a meaningful determination about permanent disability in minutes.

The government has proposed that Medical Review Panels will conduct eligibility determinations. The government has not stated how many physicians will be assigned,

what their daily caseload will be, or how they will access complete medical records for 79,290 people within any defined timeline.

The following table models what the physician workload looks like at different staffing levels, assuming the transition proceeds on schedule and reviews must be completed within an 18-month window:

Physicians Assigned	Daily Review Load	What That Actually Means
3 physicians	~24 reviews / day each	Each physician completes a full disability file review every 25 minutes, including weekends, for 549 days straight
5 physicians	~15 reviews / day each	Each physician completes a full disability file review every 40 minutes, for 549 consecutive days
10 physicians	~7-8 reviews / day each	Each physician completes a full disability file review every 75 minutes, for 549 consecutive days
20 physicians	~4 reviews / day each	Still requires 20 physicians working every single day for 549 days without interruption

CONTEXT:

Alberta's healthcare system is already facing documented physician shortages, GP vacancies, specialist waitlists, and burnout. The government is proposing to add tens of thousands of disability eligibility reviews — each requiring medical expertise and file review — to a system that cannot currently meet existing demand. No staffing plan has been published.

What a Meaningful Review Actually Requires

A disability eligibility review is not a form. For a person who has been on AISH for ten years, a meaningful review requires:

- Access to the complete medical file, including historical records, specialist reports, and diagnostic documentation accumulated over the full eligibility period
- Sufficient time to read and assess that file — not minutes, but hours for complex multi-system cases

- Clinical expertise relevant to the recipient's conditions — a generalist reviewer cannot meaningfully assess a complex neurological, psychiatric, or multi-system genetic condition
- No financial or institutional incentive to deny — the reviewing panel is appointed by the same ministry that benefits financially from reducing the AISH caseload
- An appeal mechanism if the determination is wrong — which the government has proposed to restrict or eliminate

None of these requirements have been addressed in public government communications about ADAP. The government has announced that reviews will happen. It has not said how they will be conducted with the rigour that decisions affecting permanent income require.

4. THE CONFLICT OF INTEREST BUILT INTO THE PROCESS

There is a structural problem with the review process that the volume argument alone does not fully capture, and it must be named directly.

The Government of Alberta created the AISH program. It assessed and approved 79,290 people for that program using its own eligibility criteria. It now benefits financially from reducing the number of people on that program — Budget 2025 projects AISH spending reductions of \$77 million over three years.

The Medical Review Panel that will determine who returns to AISH is appointed by the same government that benefits from that determination going a particular way. The independent review body that could correct errors in that process — the AISH Appeal Panel — has been proposed for elimination or significant restriction under ADAP.

STRUCTURAL CONFLICT:

The party with the financial interest in a particular outcome controls the decision — and has moved to eliminate the mechanism that could correct it. That is not a neutral administrative process. That is a conflict of interest written into legislation.

This does not require assuming bad faith on the part of individual reviewers. It requires only acknowledging what the structure produces: a review process where the government's fiscal interest and the government's decision-making authority point in the same direction, with no independent check.

5. WHAT HAPPENS TO PEOPLE DURING THE GAP

The administrative impossibility argument is not abstract. It has a human consequence that must be stated plainly.

If the review process cannot be completed before July 1, 2026 — and the math above strongly suggests it cannot — then one of the following must be true:

1. Recipients are transitioned to ADAP **before** their eligibility for AISH has been reviewed, meaning income protections are removed pending a determination that has not yet been made.
2. The transition deadline is extended — which the government has not announced and has not committed to.
3. The government waives the review requirement for existing recipients — which would contradict the stated purpose of the transition.
4. Recipients are expected to self-identify, self-document, and reapply — placing the administrative burden of a government process failure onto the people least equipped to carry it.

Option 4 is what is currently happening. Recipients are being asked to gather documentation, complete applications, and navigate a process whose rules have not been finalized — by a deadline that is 79 days away — without individual caseworkers, with an inaccessible call centre, and without a published review timeline.

A person who has been on AISH for ten years has structured their housing, their medical care, their caregiving arrangements, and their financial survival around a determination the government made about them. That determination is now being reversed — not because their condition changed, but because the program changed. The government made that determination. The government does not get to walk it back without a process that matches the rigour of the original decision.

6. QUESTIONS THE GOVERNMENT MUST ANSWER

This document formally requests that the Government of Alberta provide written answers to the following questions:

1. How many Medical Review Panel physicians have been appointed or contracted to conduct AISH eligibility reviews under the ADAP transition?
2. What is the expected daily review volume per physician?
3. What is the maximum review timeline — from application to decision — that the government commits to for each recipient?
4. What happens to a recipient's income and benefit status while their review is pending? Will they remain on AISH, be placed on ADAP, or receive bridge income?

5. How will the government ensure that reviewers have access to complete, longitudinal medical files — not just the most recent documentation — before making permanent eligibility determinations?
6. What safeguards will prevent reviewers from being subject to volume targets, denial quotas, or institutional pressure to reduce approvals?
7. If a recipient disagrees with a review determination, what is the appeal process, the timeline, and the income protection during appeal?
8. What is the total administrative cost of the transition — including physician fees, IT system changes, staffing, and legal analysis — and how does it compare to the projected savings?

These are not hostile questions. They are the questions any accountable government should be able to answer before implementing a system change affecting 79,290 people's income security. The fact that these answers are not publicly available is itself a finding.

7. WHAT THIS DOCUMENT REQUESTS

Based on the analysis above, this document formally requests:

- Immediate public release of the government's administrative plan for AISH eligibility reviews under the ADAP transition, including staffing levels, review timelines, and income protection during the review period.
- Written answers to the eight questions listed in Section 6, addressed within 30 days.
- A commitment that no recipient will experience income reduction as a result of the transition before their individual eligibility review has been completed and a written decision has been issued.
- Independent oversight of the Medical Review Panel process, including conflict of interest safeguards and a meaningful, independent appeal mechanism.
- A published, binding timeline for completion of all eligibility reviews — with accountability measures if that timeline is not met.

The government has had years to design this transition. It has had months since the announcement to publish its administrative plan. The absence of that plan, 79 days before the deadline, is not a minor gap in communications. It is evidence that the process has not been designed to the standard the decision requires.

A NOTE ON THE MATH

The figures in this document are derived from publicly available information: the AISH caseload figure published by the Government of Alberta, the announced July 1, 2026 transition date, and standard calendar arithmetic. No specialized access was required to

produce this analysis. Any member of the public, any journalist, any elected official, and any government employee could have run these numbers. The question is not whether the math is correct. The question is why no one in government appears to have done it before announcing the deadline.

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